what happened. Driver Rangan had gone out and spotted the police vehicles on his return. He fled the scene immediately. At that time, the tracking team was still waiting at the Bangalore office of the CBI. Despite knowing Ranganath's factory address, they could not make any move, since it was a Sunday and the factory was closed. Sri Kumar, Verma and Ragothaman had no clue about the developments in Konanakunte following Mridula's disclosure before the city's police commissioner. The DCP had no instructions from the top about taking the tracking team along.

After listening to Ragothaman's interaction with Mridula at her parents' house, Sri Kumar's take was that Sivarasan would soon feel helpless and desperate. Neither Ranganath nor Mridula had returned to the Konankunte hideout. Rangan, too, had gone missing. It would have checked Sivarasan's movements—Rangan had the Gypsy with him, and the Premier Padmini Fiat had gone to the workshop. Sri Kumar asked Verma and Ragothaman to do a recce of the area and get back soon. But reaching Konankunte did not lift their spirits. They saw that the hideout was surrounded by police vehicles and uniformed men. It was clear that the element of surprise had again been lost to the tracking team.

Anirudhya had reached Bangalore on the morning of 19 August. Verma had told him to head for Konanakunte straight from the airport, although no exact directions to the hideout were available. Verma could not speak for more than ten seconds on the phone. The private taxi brought Anirudhya to Konanakunte. It was a southern suburb of Bangalore. After about two hours of driving, the taxi stopped at the JP Nagar bus terminus, and the driver, Gopal, sought directions to Konanakunte from a tea-stall owner. Anirudhya wanted a cup of tea but time was short. Gopal made it easy for him—he brought out a thermos from his car and filled it with tea so that his customer could have it on the way and not lose any time.

Back in the car, Gopal asked if something had happened in Konanakunte. Apparently, while buying tea, he had heard bystanders talk